# 2026-10-11 — נשמת כל חי: Layers, Legends, and the Question of Authorship

*Independent review · read fresh, no exposure to the writing process · 11 October 2026 · second read, against the reconciled text*

## 1.Overall Read

A twelve-section write-up of roughly 8,200 words (the abstract and body, before the apparatus; up from about 6,300 in the earlier draft) with a twenty-nine-note *Mareh Mekomos*, built on a genuinely good idea: treat נשמת as an archaeological site and dig down through it. The layers come in a sensible order: ברכת השיר on the fourth cup (III), the rain thanksgiving ואילו פינו (IV), the Chida's Kloynimus lines (V), the late רבקה / יצחק section (VI). Then the piece turns from *layers* to *authors*: the Rokeach (VII), Reb Hertz Treves's reversed שמעון (VIII), and the Shimon Kipa / Peter legend (IX). It closes with *why Shabbos* (X), the Chasidic experience of Nishmas with the Reb Moshe Wolfson testimony (XI), and an honest "I don't know" on שוכן עד (XII). The best passages are still the Kloynimus story (V), the Machzor Vitry's יצחק ורבקה objection (VI), and the Wolfson memory (XI). The Rav's candour ("a little confused myself as to the timeline") is the right posture for the material.

The reconciliation to the fuller transcript has made the text richer, and in places better (see the resolved list below), but it has also **added more working-draft material to the body** than the earlier version carried. The hard problems now are six. (a) **The piece still never reconciles its two models.** "Nishmas as stacked layers by different hands" (III–VI) and "Nishmas as one composition by one famous author" (VII–IX) are not adjudicated. There is now one sentence that comes near it (X: "Klal Yisrael accepted all of Nishmas, with its different parts composed at different times") and a gesture in the closing box ("one layer after another that Klal

Yisrael accepted whole … whether Shimon ben Shetach or the other Shimon"), but both sit at the very end, neither says that a single-author acrostic running through the whole text is incompatible with a Kloynimus-era insertion, and the abstract and section headings still announce "wild authorship claims" rather than a thesis. (b) **The Kloynimus chronology is still incoherent** (700–800 years / Ottoman Pasha / "a couple of centuries ago"). It is now cross-referenced to note 5 from the body, which is an improvement in honesty and a regression in readability, and the note still says "no date is asserted." (c) **The Peter section still reads as endorsement** in its closing beats ("So Nishmas comes from Peter," "a lot of things point to the story being true," "this we know from the New Testament"), the Rav's promised "purpose" is never stated, and two different yahrzeits are now given for Shimon Kipa (see §3). (d) **Transcript residue has grown, not shrunk**: a dedication paragraph with four personal names and an "all names to be confirmed" instruction, a "Sofer text" reference, "(reconstructed, not heard)," "apparently pointing to a source; see note 15," and a closing clock time. (e) **The footnotes are working notes, not book notes**: every one of the twenty-nine ends in a bold "Flag," twelve or so are genuinely unresolved, the voice is the editor's ("I have not verified," "the editor's identification"), and "Sefaria" now appears thirty-four times in the apparatus. (f) **Some factual statements in the body are wrong or doubtful on their face** (the extent of Nishmas, the Algazi relationship, Shimon ben Shetach's "talmid," the two Kipa yahrzeits, a "zt"l" on a living rav if that is the case; see §4).

**Resolved or improved since the earlier version of this review (not repeated below).**

- "The recording garbles this" / "as heard on the recording" no longer appear in the body (they survive only in notes 13, 15 and 27).

- The Baruch Ta'am is now named (Rabbi Baruch Frankel-Teomim, Rav of

Leipnik, father-in-law of the Tzanzer Rav). The earlier objection that he was "unnamed and uncheckable" is met.

- Shimon ben Shetach is now correctly placed as the *rebbi* of Shemaya and Avtalyon (consistent with Avos 1:10). The earlier "alongside Shemaya and Avtalyon" error is gone. (A new problem in the same sentence is in §4.)

•"Reb Hertz Shatz" is explained in the body (ץ" , שchazzan who knew the tefillos), and the Treves identification is flagged in note 13.

•The body now says "as the Rav reports it / paraphrases" for the Machzor Vitry's "later couple" and korban chatas statements, and the "Rokeach vs. Chida" tension is at least acknowledged in one parenthetical ("doesn't fit" with what the Chida said). It is not yet explained (see §3).

•The Mishnah Berurah latecomer paragraph (II) is correctly sourced to the Rav in note 1; the siman and se'ifim are identified. The substantive "say Nishmas after davening" claim is still unlocated (see §4).

•The "Yoske" register problem is gone; the Peter material now uses "Yeshke" (with the traditional curse formula) consistently. "Yeshke" itself is still a house-style question (§5).

•The closing mishnah (Makkos 3:16) and Yadayim 3:5 are now correctly identified; the fn 18 / fn 25 style problems from before are narrower than they were.

## 2.What Works

- **The "one long tefillah" opening (I).** Getting the reader to see נשמת → ישתבח as one sweep, with Pesukei DeZimra sandwiched between two berachos, is a clean orientation, and the four questions give the shiur a spine. The question of Q4 ("why does Klal Yisrael take it so seriously") is

now properly answered at the front by the latecomer halachah in II, which is a good structural choice (but see §4 on its source).

- **The first three layers (III–V).** Gemara Pesachim (the fourth cup) → Gemara Berachos (rain) → Chida (Kloynimus) is easy to follow, and "two distinct texts from two different Talmudic contexts, welded into one" remains the best statement of the thesis.
- **Kloynimus Ba'al HaNes (V).** Still well told and well sub-headed (setting, miracle, Shabbos detail, burial, from the miracle to the text, Gaonic proof). The reconciled version adds the stone-vow custom and the explicit mapping of each line to the story, and the Rav's stated stance ("you don't have to believe the story … I believe it") is exactly the right register.
- **The blood-libel passage.** Handled soberly; the point that blood libels were not only a Christian phenomenon is made once, factually.
- **The acrostic section (VI).** Showing the letters and then the Machzor Vitry's "why Shacharis if Yitzchak instituted Minchah?" is the piece at its best: text, puzzle, source's reaction. The reader now also gets the third-letters derivation of רבקה in prose.
- **Shimon ben Shetach (VIII)** and **the turn to Shimon Kipa (IX)**. The reversed acrostic is vivid; "That's why שמעון, not שמעון בן שטח" (the closing line of "The Fast of the Ninth of Teves") is the clearest single statement of why the two candidates compete for the same name. It should be moved earlier.
- **Reasons for Shabbos (X).** The three reasons now carry sources (Beitzah 16a; Tur OC 281; Devarim 5:15), and the "when did it enter the seder" paragraph at last gives the Rav's one real answer ("accepted all of Nishmas, with its different parts composed at different times").
- **The Wolfson testimony and the Yesod VeShoresh HaAvodah (XI).** The emotional centre of the piece. The "I felt like I'm standing

next to a malach" passage is the right closing note for the Chasidic section; the reconciled text keeps it intact.

- **The apparatus is honest.** Note 1, note 9, note 18, note 22 each say plainly what was and was not found. That honesty is correct; the only problem is its form (§4).

## 3.Where It's Weak or Could Be Sharper

**Layers vs. single authorship: still not stated as a problem.** The title announces "Layers, Legends, and the Question of Authorship," and the reader is promised an argument. What the text actually contains is two blocks. III–VI say Nishmas is a composite (Seder-night ברכת השיר, the rain-prayer, the Kloynimus lines, a late coda). VII–IX say it was written by one person: the Anshei Knesses HaGedolah / Ezra (III), the Rokeach's pre-Mishnaic first tefillah, Shimon ben Shetach, or Shimon Kipa. These cannot all be true, and the reader is never told which pairs collide. The collisions that a book must name are: (1) the acrostic runs through שמעון ואילו, עד הנה, מי ידמה, שוועת, בשמת. across the very paragraphs III–IV assign to a Seder-night text and a rain-prayer, so an acrostic author is either redacting the already-welded text or the layers theory is wrong; (2) the Rokeach's "ancient replacement for Birchos HaShachar" (VII) puts the cluster מתיר אסורים ... סומך נופלים ... מעורר ישנים before the Gemara, while V gives the same cluster to Reb Kloynimus after the Geonim (the body now concedes, in a parenthetical, that it "doesn't fit" with the Chida, and goes no further); (3) the Machzor Vitry appears with two unrelated claims (VI: no Yitzchak and Rivka; IX: a korban chatas for saying Peter wrote it). A single synopsis after VI (or at the end of I), a table of "claimed author / date / which part of the text / who says it / who rejects it," would let the reader see the whole fight. The one sentence in X that comes closest ("accepted all of Nishmas, with its different parts composed at different times") should be promoted to the end of I as the thesis and repeated at the close.

**The Kloynimus timeline is still internally incoherent, and the body now says so in its own text.** The Chida's Revelation says "700 to 800 years ago." "The Man and His Title" says "700 years ago, approximately." The setting says

the Ottomans (Pasha). The close of the section says "a couple of centuries ago … (earlier he said about 700 years ago; see note 5)." Note 5 then says "No date is asserted here." A printed book cannot say 700 years, 200 years and "no date" in the same section. The clean resolution: the Chida's own claim (as relayed by the Rav) is that the lines were added after the Geonim; the "Ottoman / Pasha" detail is anachronistic for a story set c. 1200 (Jerusalem then was Ayyubid or, shortly after, Mamluk, and "Pasha" is an Ottoman title from after 1517); and the Chida (d. 1806) and Algazi (d. 1756) are eighteenth-century *reporters*. Print one of those two stories, label the other the Rav's recollection, and delete the "see note 5" from the body. Also gloss קלונימוס once and say plainly that he is not (as far as we know) the Kalonymus family of Mainz and Lucca.

**Two different yahrzeits for Shimon Kipa are given and not reconciled.** "The Fast of the Ninth of Teves" says the Baruch Ta'am found a manuscript that the ninth of Teves is the day Shimon HaKipa passed away. "The Seder Avodah of Yom Kippur" then says the Rav "ties this to why we commemorate his yahrzeit on that day" (Yom Kippur). The reader cannot tell whether these are two traditions, an error, or the Rav ironically adding a second. Either present them as two competing legends or drop one. In the same paragraph the body says the ninth of Teves is "one of the fasts we no longer keep" and then closes "We commemorate it by fasting because of the great service he did for Klal Yisrael." That last sentence is the Rav's gloss, stated in the present tense, and it directly contradicts the Shulchan Aruch's report (the body's own) that nobody knows what happened that day. Say: "On this view, the day would be Shimon Kipa's yahrzeit; the fast is not observed for that reason."

**The "purpose" of the Peter section is still never stated, and the framing is still apologetic.** "I'm saying it for a purpose" and "I'm going to say it because other Rishonim do say it" both appear, and the purpose never does. The section closes with (in order) a ninth-of-Teves paragraph, a Machzor Vitry rebuke, an etymology of "Peter" and "Kefa," a midrash that Peter returned to Yiddishkeit, the Avodah attribution, and an "asides from the room" block ending in the Rome advice and a Chabad joke. A framing paragraph at the top of IX would solve most of it: what the tradition is (a medieval Ashkenazi folk legend with the "Shimon Kepha" figure also found in the *Toledot Yeshu* material), what it is for (it explains a puzzling acrostic and it explains why a prayer was

suspected), and that the Machzor Vitry and Sefer Chasidim, as the Rav reports them, reject it. Then tell the story. As it stands the rejection comes sixth of eight sub-sections.

**Sensitive passages: the balance is better than before but the register still slips.** The Rav's disclaimers ("an urban myth, but it has sources," "according to our tradition this is all made up," "the Machzor Vitry was furious") are the right moves, and note 15 now carries the key sentence ("no scholarly-historical basis"). What still undercuts them: (1) "*(and 'this we know from the New Testament').*" The same sentence then lists Shabbos-to-Sunday, Pesach-to-Easter, Shavuos-to-Pentecost, Sukkos-to-Christmas and Shemini Atzeres-to-New Year's. Note 16 says the NT does not attribute these to Peter. The body should say "the legend claims," not "we know." Pentecost *is* Shavuos in the NT itself (Acts 2); Christmas and New Year's have no NT basis. (2) "*So Nishmas comes from Peter,*" "*a lot of things point to the story being true,*" "*there has to be some part of this legend [that has] to be true.*" These are the Rav's rhetorical beats; in print they read as conclusions. Recast as "this is the shape of the legend." (3) "*cult,*" "*the scoundrel, Peter the donkey,*" "*Yeshke*" are used without a signal that the second is medieval polemic and the third is a traditional circumlocution. (4) *The Rome aside* ("I told him not to go … if you went there, do teshuvah") is a personal psak reported colourfully; one neutral sentence suffices. (5) *The Chabad joke* "*that he chose not to say*" is printed, contradicting its own caption. Cut. (6) *The Kipa / Ziskind quip* in XI ("like Shimon Kipa, by the Misnagdim") makes sense only if the reader remembers the infiltration legend; either explain in a clause or cut.

**Section II still rests on an unverified halachah.** The framing ("the true measure of its status") is that the Mishnah Berurah requires one who skipped Nishmas to say it *after* davening, while Shirat HaYam need not be made up. Note 1 now says plainly that MB 52:5–6 confirm only that Nishmas is obligatory on Shabbos for the latecomer, that 52:9 is about Torah blessings and אלהי נשמה, and that the "say it afterwards" point "was not located … treat it as the Rav's report." That honesty belongs in the body, not only in the note: "As the Rav understands the Mishnah Berurah …" or, better, locate the source (try the Biur Halachah and Shaar HaTziyun on 52, and the poskim on *tashlumin* for skipped Pesukei DeZimra).

**Section X: three reasons, no evaluation.** Nishmas is also said on Yom Tov, which has no משמה יתירה; the Rav himself reports that Chasidim said it daily. The three reasons (more time; neshamah yeseirah; Yetzias Mitzrayim) should be tested against that data in two lines each: "this explains Shabbos but not Yom Tov." Note 24 also shows that the Tur ties Nishmas itself to the exodus (the reason it follows the Shirah), not Shabbos, so the body's Reason Three does not state what the Tur says; the Rav was unsure whether it was the Tur. Add: "(the Rav was not certain this is the Tur)" or correct the body to the Tur's actual point.

**Narrative monotony (reportage voice).** "The Rav" appears 88 times in the body in lower case and 59 times as a sentence opener, with "The Rav says" 10, "the Rav says" 15, "The Rav adds" 7, "the Rav adds" 3, "the Rav notes" 7. Twenty-nine parentheticals begin "(the Rav …)," eight of them as direct quotations of his memory or lack of it ("the Rav: 'it's a whole siman'; he gave no number"). The reportage voice is workable for a shiur summary but flattens the best stories, and the parenthetical habit gives a note-taker's feel. For the Sefer Edition convert the narrative passages (V, XI) to direct narration and keep attribution only at claims.

**Redundancy.** (i) The forty-days-at-the-Kosel custom appears in VII (with "more on this below") and again as a stand-alone sub-section in XI. Keep XI; cut VII. (ii) The Birchos HaShachar parallel is made in V, VII and note 11. (iii) "I don't know" / "confused" occurs in I, VII (once, indirectly), X (twice), XII (twice); keep two. (iv) The abstract and the "For Next Shabbos" box summarise the same thing at different lengths, and the box repeats the acrostic derivation. (v) The שמעון reverse-acrostic is spelled out letter by letter in VIII *and again*, in prose, in the last paragraph of "The Fast of the Ninth of Teves." (vi) "He peels back its layers" appears in the abstract and the closing box. (vii) "fascinated / fascinating" occurs four times. (viii) The caution that the Rav "does not know" which Tanna Shimon Kipa was is given twice.

## 4.Factual / Citation Concerns

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|---|---|
| **Where Nishmas ends vs. where** | **פי ישרים its (I, VI, XII).** |

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|---|---|
| Unresolved from the earlier read. I says Nishmas runs "from | נשמת ואילו |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| VI says the late ובְּכֵן יִשְׁתַּבַּח | and then straight into שוכן עד | the way to |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| the Rav: שוכן עד | . all the way through וכל הלבבות | section runs "from |

| | |
|---|---|
| as part of that בפי ישרים | 'until Yishtabach')." The body then analyses |

| | |
|---|---|
| שוכן עד מרום וקדוש שמו | section. As I know the standard text, וכתוב רננו . |

| | |
|---|---|
| so the stated range שוכן עד | runs *after* בפי ישרים תתרומם ... וצדיקים |

excludes the line it examines. The Rav's own "until Yishtabach" is the

| | |
|---|---|
| is the editor's שוכן עד | accurate end; the body's replacement of it with |

| | |
|---|---|
| is where the שוכן עד | error. Please check a siddur. Same for XII: |

chazzan *begins*, not where Nishmas ends.

| | |
|---|---|
| שוועת | **The reverse acrostic's paragraph order (VIII).** The body lists |

as the "paragraphs from the end." As I נשמת → ואילו → עד הנה → מי ידמה

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| in the text (so מי ידמה לך | precedes שוועת עניים | know the siddur, |

reading back from the end the order would be ה before ש (ש and in

most printed siddurim neither begins a new paragraph; the Treves text

presumably paragraphed differently. Please verify against the Treves

siddur and state which text the acrostic reads off; otherwise a sharp

reader will check it with a printed siddur and not find the pattern.

Relatedly, the Gemara's text (Berachos 59b, note 3) is שילו without the

vav, and the acrostic needs the siddur's שׁאילו. Say so in one sentence:

it shows the acrostic was built on the already-welded siddur text.

**Algazi (V, note 5).** The body says Reb Yisrael Yaakov Algazi was "the

Maharit Algazi's son." Note 5(a) says reference works have it the other

way. They do: R. Yom Tov Algazi (the Maharit, 1727–1802) is the *son* of

R. Yisrael Yaakov Algazi (c. 1680–1756), so the body is wrong as printed

and should read "father of the Maharit." Name the work, as note 5(b) says

it was not named. The Rav's own double self-correction on the name order is process residue and can go.

**Date and chronology of the Kloynimus layer (V, notes 5–6).** See §3. In addition: the Chida's *Simchas HaRegel* passage is "could not be retrieved" (note 4), and it is the single most important citation in the piece; obtain it and quote two lines before print. The Gaonic proof (note 6: Rav Amram and Rav Saadia lack the lines) is likewise "not verified." Since the whole "later addition" claim depends on it, compare the two critical editions and give page numbers. "A thousand years ago" for Rav Amram (9th c.) and Rav Saadia (10th c.) is loose; say "ninth and tenth centuries."

The Rokeach (d. c. 1238) and the Machzor Vitry (c. 1100) are said to know the cluster, which sits badly with a post-Geonic Jerusalem author; this should be stated, not left for the reader to discover.

**Zugos (VIII, note 14).** The body now says Shimon ben Shetach was the rebbi of Shemaya and Avtalyon (correct per Avos 1:10), but also reports "his talmid is Rabbi Yehoshua ben Perachya." On the Avos sequence (1:6, 1:8) Yehoshua ben Perachya belongs to the *earlier* pair and Shimon ben Shetach to the next; note 14 says as much and records the body as "his words." In the Gemara's Yeshu story (Sanhedrin 107b) Yehoshua ben Perachya is Yeshu's teacher and a contemporary of Shimon ben Shetach in Yannai's reign. Either rephrase ("the era of the Zugos, in which Yeshu's teacher Yehoshua ben Perachya also lived") or drop. Note: the whole of X's "Reb Mordechai" paragraph asks whether Shimon ben Shetach (Yannai's reign, first century BCE) and Shimon Kipa (first century CE) can be one person; a reader will see the century-long gap at once, and no reply is given. Add a sentence on the gap or cut the paragraph

(see §5).

**Calendar claims attributed to Peter (IX, note 16).** As printed:

Pesach (the Last Supper) became Easter; Shavuos became Pentecost;

Sukkos became Christmas; Shemini Atzeres became New Year's.

Pentecost is the Greek name for Shavuos, not a replacement; the last two

have no New Testament or early-church basis; the Last Supper-as-Seder

is the Synoptic chronology and John dates it differently. Flag each as "the

legend claims" in the body. The Hebrew "Krazmach" and the explanation

"(the Rav's Yiddish for Christmas)" are fine in a shiur, but a book should

say "Christmas" and put the Yiddish in a note. "The Rav says he knows

exactly where in the New Testament this is but will not say 'because

you're going to think I'm crazy'" is a joke about the reader; cut.

**Peter and Paul, Latin and Greek (IX, note 20).** "Patrus … the name in ancient Latin" and note 20's "from the Greek Petros" are not the same: Petros is Greek, Petrus Latin. Pick one. "Taken to Rome, where he died" is Catholic tradition and is stated as fact; phrase it as tradition. The claims that Peter returned to Yiddishkeit in a tower in Rome, wrote piyutim and sent Nishmas to Chazal are the Rav's "another midrash" and should stay tagged as such (they currently are, but only inside the sentence). The Atah Konanta attribution (note 21) is the Rav's report of the legend; scholarship attributes אתה כוננת עולם מראש to Yose ben Yose, and the body should say that in a clause. The statement "the machzor says you're not allowed to say it" is explicitly ambiguous in the text (what is "it"? which machzor?); either resolve or drop the sentence.

**Machzor Vitry (VI, IX, X; notes 9, 18, 22).** Verified: the §161

objection to Yitzchak and Rivka (note 9). Not found: (i) the "later couple"

conclusion (note 9, and the body is now correctly hedged "as the Rav

reports"); (ii) the korban chatas / פטר חמור passage (note 18); (iii) Atah

Konanta forbidden (note 21); (iv) "Nishmas daily in place of Birchos

HaShachar" (note 22). Of five Machzor Vitry claims in the piece, one is

verified. The abstract still says the Machzor Vitry "so fiercely rejects" the

Peter legend as if it were established. Either find the passages (Hurwitz

edition; Order of Yom Kippur; the Nishmas commentary) or phrase every

instance "the Rav reports." The "Rashi's מיוחסין description (note 18)

should be checked or reduced to "a student of Rashi."

**Treves (VIII, note 13).** Body: "One of the very first siddurim printed in

the history of printing" is an overstatement (printed siddurim go back to

the 1480s); say "one of the earliest printed Ashkenazi siddurim with a

commentary." The identification with Naftali Hertz Treves (Thiengen

1560) is flagged in note 13 and not in the body, and the page of his

remark on Nishmas is not given; the whole Shimon ben Shetach section

depends on it. Also, the Rav says Treves "cites a yesh omrim" about

Shimon ben Shetach and later "the most controversial thing that was ever

said about anything in our seder," which the reader would take to be the

Peter legend. Note 15 admits the recording does not say who carries the

Peter version (Treves, the midrash, other Rishonim, the Tashbetz). The

body should either say "the Rav reports that Treves quotes it" or not

attribute it. The "Tashbetz" aside (IX, "That's over here, Tashbetz, right?")

is unresolved: if it means the Tashbetz (R. Shimon b. Tzemach Duran) it is

a very surprising source; if it is a book the Rav is holding, name it.

**Ashkenaz vs. Sefard (V, X; note 7).** Note 7 says the Rav did not

specify which lines Ashkenaz omits. As I know the standard texts, the difference is the line והמפענח נעלמים. Nusach Sefard has it and standard Ashkenaz does not. This matters, because that is one of the two lines the Rav's Kloynimus story hangs on. Please verify and state it in the body; the Rav's hedging in X ("I'm not sure about that exactly, why the difference") is then a real, stateable answer, not an unresolved aside.

**Reb Moshe Wolfson (XI, note 27).** The body twice gives him the honorifics of the deceased (זצ"ל; זקנ"ר צדיק לברכה) and note 27 says "as the Rav said." I do not know whether he has passed. If he is alive, the honorific is a serious error in a printed book; if he has passed, add the date. Also: the ages ("eighty-nine, ninety") and "two or three months every winter" are the Rav's memory; given as such they are fine. "Reb Yisroel Dovid … 'the Munies'" is residue (see §5).

**Rokeach (VII, XI; notes 10, 26).** No siman; Sefer HaRokeach is not indexed on Sefaria. Two of the shiur's most striking claims (Nishmas is the first tefillah, predating Rebbi; Nishmas is the Shir HaShirim of tefillah) rest on one unlocated source. Locate, or print "the Rav cites the Rokeach." Also XI's "Yesod VeShoresh HaAvodah" paragraph attributes a rule (that Nishmas is said בקול רם ובנעימה to "the Rokeach, one of the Rishonim"; note 28 says the sentence is ambiguous. Print as ambiguity or resolve.

**Yesod VeShoresh HaAvodah (XI, note 28).** The simchah passage on Nishmas "was not located" (Gate 3 is the right gate for Pesukei DeZimra). The superlative "he writes something he writes about no other tefillah" is the Rav's. "About 200 years ago" for Ziskind (d. 1794) is nearer 230.

"Horodna" is the Rav's pronunciation; the book should use Grodno only

(the text does, in the parenthesis, but keeps the Rav's version).

**Tosafos and "individuals only in the times of Chazal" (X, note 25).**

Note 25 says the Tosafos text on Sefaria does not say what the body says Tosafos says, and the Gaonic claim is "not checked." This is the Rav's only direct answer to Q3, and it is unsupported. Either find it (the Gaonic siddurim, *Seder Rav Amram* on Shabbos morning) or print "as the Rav understands it."

**Dates and internal consistency.** 11 October 2026 = 30 Tishrei 5787 is correct, and it is a Sunday, consistent with the "welcome to Mar-Cheshvan" aside and with "Rosh Chodesh." "Seven or eight weeks ago" matches 16 August exactly (eight weeks). Note 18's "the 16 August 2026 shiur" cross-reference must go: a book cannot point to a dated shiur.

"Rabbi Ephrati" appears in the header and footer, while the project style elsewhere is "Efratti"; decide. The "Mar-Cheshvan, the rain season" aside works only if the reader knows the date: in print add "Rosh Chodesh Cheshvan" (the natural link to the 7 Cheshvan request for rain is not made).

### Footnotes and the "note-academic" flags: what a book edition must resolve or move to endnotes

> All twenty-nine notes still carry a bold "Flag." Sorted by what the flag says:

- **Verified, with only an editor's identification needed (clean after style repair):** 1 (MB 52), 2 (Pesachim), 3 (Berachos 59b; with the אילו point), 8 (Bereishis 25:21), 9 (Berachos 26b; MV §161), 11 (Berachos 60b), 14 (Avos 1; Berachos 48a), 16 (Acts 10), 20 (Matthew 16; John 1:42), 23 (Beitzah 16a), 24 (Tur 281; Devarim 5:15), 26 (Yadayim 3:5). Twelve notes. The editor's identification of the siman or amud should simply be absorbed into a clean citation.

- **Oral testimony or custom, no printed source needed:** 12 (Kosel custom), 27 (Wolfson). These go to the body as attributed testimony; the note is unnecessary.

- **Genuinely unresolved, needs a library or must be printed as "the Rav reports":** 4 (Chida, Simchas HaRegel), 5 (Algazi: relationship wrong, work unnamed, dates), 6 (Gaonic siddurim), 10 (Rokeach), 13

(Treves page), 17 (Baruch Ta'am gloss), 18 (Machzor Vitry korban chatas), 19 (Sefer Chasidim), 21 (Atah Konanta), 22 (Machzor Vitry daily), 25 (Tosafos), 28 (Yesod VeShoresh HaAvodah). Twelve notes.

- **Ambiguous or contradictory with the body:** 7 (which lines; see §4), 15 (the Peter legend: who carries it), 29 (shliach tzibbur descent: Rosh Hashanah is the editor's addition and should be in the body if correct). Three notes.

Problems that apply to the apparatus as a whole:

- **Voice.** First person and process language ("I have not verified," "the editor's identification," "this is the Rav's report," "treat it as the Rav's report") appears in nearly every note. A book cannot have it. Split each note in two: a clean source line (and the Rav's claim, if it needs stating), and a separate *Editorial Log* outside the book for "unresolved."

- **Platform vs. source.** "Sefaria" now appears thirty-four times in the notes and three times in the body. A book cites the work and place ("Berachos 59b," "Machzor Vitry, Order of Shabbat §161"), not the website. Keep Sefaria links for the web edition only.

- **Notes that contradict the body.** Note 5(c) (no date asserted) vs. the body's "700 to 800 years ago"; note 9 (the "later couple" not found) vs. the body, now hedged; note 24 (the Tur ties Nishmas, not Shabbos, to the exodus) vs. Reason Three; note 15 vs. IX's "this we know from the New Testament."

- **Notes carrying content that belongs in the body.** 15 ("no scholarly-historical basis") and 16 ("the NT does not attribute this to Peter") are the balance of IX and need to be promoted; 1 (the "say it after davening" claim is the Rav's report, not located) belongs in II.

- **Body text that is itself note-like.** Nine parenthetical interventions in the

> body address the editor or the reader of the file: "(see note 5 on the Rav's chronology)," "(see note 2)," "(see note 15)," "(see note 28)," "(apparently a further dedicatee; the Rav's wording is not entirely clear, so this is for the Rav to confirm)," "(reconstructed, not heard)," "(The question itself does not appear in the Sofer text …)," "(the sentence does not make clear …)," "All names … are to be confirmed with the Rav before printing." All must move to the Editorial Log or be resolved.

- **The closing "Editor's source note"** on Makkos 3:16 sits in the body
  > after the last line of the shiur. Make it note 30 or delete; the mishnah itself (חנניה בן עקשיא ב) is the correct close.

- **Numbering.** Notes are in strict body order (1–29). No re-sequencing is
  > needed. Note 11 sits on VII's Birchos HaShachar sentence but V's parallel has no pointer; add a back-reference. Note 9 and note 18 should cross-reference each other (both Machzor Vitry).

## 5.Small Polish Suggestions

- **The dedication paragraph (I).** It is two paragraphs of dedications, four personal names (Reb Meir Weissman, a father-in-law and grandfather by first name and patronymic, ר׳ יוסי גבאי טהרה, "Danny Kriegsman, 'I'm sure many of you knew him'"), a bracketed instruction to the Rav to confirm the names, the Yiddish blessing, and the coffee break. In a book this is a dedication page, not part of the chapter. Replace with one sentence ("The shiur was dedicated לעילוי נשמת departed relatives of members of the shul") or move to the book's front matter with confirmed names.

- **Congregants' names throughout.** Reb Meir Weissman, Danny Kriegsman (I); Reb David (IX); Ari (IX); Reb Mordechai, Reb Chezkel, "Rav Yitzchak's wife," "Rebbetzin Kolodetzky … Rav Chaim Kanievsky's daughter," Reb Yisroel Dovid (X, XI). Replace each with "a member of the shul" / "a participant," or cut the passage. The

Kolodetzky passage and "I'm not joining her minyan, now I know" are a personal joke; cut.

- **Transcript residue in the body to cut:** (IV) "(the Rav: 'it's a whole siman'; he gave no number)"; "welcome to Mar-Cheshvan" (IV, add the date); "Daf Kuf Yud Ches, amud alef" and "daf Nun Tes" (III, IV) as quoted daf-names (use "118a" and "59b"); (VII) "the shiur spoke about Birchos HaShachar on Shabbos morning at Chumash Rashi"; (VIII) "The Rav says the group did not visit his grave in Frankfurt; 'we should go back'"; (VIII) "I wrote it down for myself because I knew I'd forget it"; (IX) "(the Rav interrupts himself, 'they didn't have yarmulkes back then')"; (X) "Yes, Reb Mordechai, I'm sorry"; (X) "Reb Chezkel says moradik"; (XI) "I'm calling them the Munies"; (XI) "at the beis medrash of Harborview he has to rush it a bit, and takes a reminder to finish on time as 'tochachas tzibbur, chas v'shalom'"; (XII) "because it is 10:45 and late, and he notes that there are a couple more things to say"; (IX) the Chabad joke; (IX) the eBay "bones of Peter."

- **Headings.** "Machzor Vitry's Fury, and Sefer Chasidim" → "The Rishonim's Rejection." "Some Asides from the Room" → "Questions from the Room" (and move it below the rejection). "A Daily Tefillah for Pious Individuals" and "When Did It Enter the Seder?" are sub-headings of X at the same level as "Reason One/Two/Three"; make the structure parallel. The heading "VI. A Much Later Section (the Rav's Claim)" should drop the parenthesis (state the claim in the first line).

- **Section IX order.** Move "Machzor Vitry's Fury, and Sefer Chasidim" ahead of "What Peter Did" and "The Fast of the Ninth of Teves," and add the framing paragraph (§3). Move "Why 'Peter'? Why 'Kefa'?" ahead of "What Peter Did," since the name is the first thing the reader needs.

- **Abstract.** The sentence beginning "He peels back its layers" is a 130-word chain; the parenthetical "(Sefer Chasidim (ספר חסידים) also calls

him פטר חמור, though it says he began as a tzaddik)" is nested inside a clause and unreadable. Split into three or four sentences and replace "wild authorship claims" with "competing authorship traditions."

- **Subtitle.** "From נשמת to שוכן עד — Birchas HaShir and the rain-prayer, Reb Kloynimus Ba'al HaNes, the יצחק/רבקה acrostic, שמעון בן שטח and שמעון כיפא, and the Chasidic fire of Nishmas" duplicates the abstract. Shorten.

- **Acrostic quotation (VI): still not fixed.** The four bold initials have lost their vowels (the י of ישרים needs a sheva, the צ of צדיקים a patach, the ח of חסידים a chataf-patach, the ק of קדושים a sheva). Put the vowels inside the bold tag. Add a second quoted line with the third letters of תתרומם, תתברך, תתקדש, תתהלל in bold so the reader can see רבקה as well as יצחק.

- **Hebrew pointing policy.** Quoted blocks are fully pointed; in-line Hebrew is sometimes pointed (נִשְׁמַת כָּל חַי in I, הַנָּבָל פֶּטֶר חֲמוֹר in IX) and mostly not (נשמת everywhere else). House style: point quoted pesukim and tefillah text; leave in-line terms unpointed. The title in the head is "Nishmas Kol Chai (נשמת כל חי)" while the body uses "Nishmas" and נשמת interchangeably; pick one for running text.

- **Transliteration to unify:** Kipa / HaKipa / Kefa / Cephas (use *Shimon Kefa* once with the legend's כיפא gloss, then one form); "Shirat HaYam" (four) vs. the piece's -as/-os style, so "Shiras HaYam"; "Sefard" (consistent) vs. the Rav's "Misnagdim" (use "Misnagdim"); "Ba'al HaNes" (consistent) vs. "Baal Shem Tov" and "Baal HaTanya" (pick Baal/Ba'al); "Chasidic" (consistent) vs. "Chasidish" in quotes (leave in quotes only); "Rivka" (consistent); "Machzor Vitry"; "Yeshke" (see below); "Shimon HaKipa" vs. "Shimon Kipa"; "Rabbi Ephrati" vs. "Efratti" in the rest of the project.

- **"Yeshke" / "Yeshu."** The Rav's "Yeshke, ימח שמו וזכרו" is the right traditional circumlocution in the room but will be read in print as hostile. Use "Yeshu" once with a gloss and then "Jesus"; keep the

curse formula only where the Rav is directly quoted.

- **"Peter the donkey."** Explain the pun once: פטר חמור (the firstborn of a donkey, Shemos 13:13) rhymes with פטר (Peter); the Machzor Vitry (as reported) uses the epithet as insult. Also, "scoundrel" (נבל) should be translated "villain" or "degenerate," not "scoundrel," for tone.
  - **Forty days at the Kosel.** The paragraph in VII ("all over Eretz Yisrael they go to the Kosel for forty days in a row … and get a shidduch. It is a new thing; the mekubalim say to do it") and the sub-section in XI are word-for-word duplicates. Keep the XI version.
- **Section XII.** Three hedges in four lines ("the answer is Kabbalah," "I don't know," "it's confusing, complicated"). Compress to: "The Rav did not give a reason; some attribute it to Kabbalah." State the factual line (Shabbos: שוכן עד; Yom Tov: האל בתעצומות עזך; Yom Kippur: המלך) and, if note 29's Rosh Hashanah addition is right, add it in the body.
- **"For Next Shabbos" box.** Good in principle; it restates the acrostic (including בְּפִי יְשָׁרִים), which a book would not do. Keep two sentences: the two Kloynimus lines and the acrostic hint.

### Consolidated recommended edits (for the Sefer Edition rewrite)

1. Add a synopsis (table: claimed author / date / which part of the text / source / who rejects it) after VI, naming the three collisions (acrostic vs. layers; Rokeach vs. Kloynimus; Machzor Vitry's two claims). State that "layers" and "single author" cannot both be right and say where the Rav lands (or that he does not).
2. Promote the X sentence "Klal Yisrael accepted all of Nishmas, with its different parts composed at different times" to the end of I as the thesis; repeat it at the close; replace the abstract's "wild authorship claims" and the subtitle catalogue.
3. Restate the four opening questions at the end with a one-line "where

we got" under each; delete "because it is 10:45 and late."

4. Fix the Kloynimus chronology in the body (V): choose one account; delete "see note 5" from the body; label "Ottoman / Pasha" as the Rav's inference; reconcile with note 5(c); state that Chida and Algazi are eighteenth-century reporters; address the Rokeach (d. c. 1238) and Machzor Vitry (c. 1100) already knowing the cluster.
5. Gloss קלונימוס and distinguish from the Kalonymus family.
6. Correct "Reb Yisrael Yaakov Algazi, the Maharit Algazi's son" to "father of the Maharit"; name the work.
7. Correct the extent of Nishmas: the Rav's "until Yishtabach" is right; בפי ישרים follows עד שוכן. Fix I, VI and XII.
8. Verify the Treves text and the order of paragraph-initials for the שמעון acrostic; state which text it reads off; add the אילו/ואילו sentence.
9. Qualify "one of the very first siddurim printed in the history of printing"; give the Treves page; settle "Treves / Hertz Shatz."
10. Fix the Zugos sentence: drop or rephrase "his talmid is Rabbi Yehoshua ben Perachya"; source "Shlomtzion" separately; add one sentence on the century between Shimon ben Shetach and Shimon Kipa, or cut the Reb Mordechai paragraph.
11. Put a framing paragraph at the top of IX (what the legend is, its likely home in *Toledot Yeshu*-type material, what it is for, who rejects it); state the Rav's "purpose" or delete both promises of it.
12. Reorder IX: rejection (Machzor Vitry, Sefer Chasidim) first; names ("Peter," "Kefa") before "What Peter Did"; ninth of Teves and Atah Konanta after.
13. Replace "this we know from the New Testament" with "the legend claims"; tag Pentecost, Christmas, New Year's explicitly; promote notes 15 and 16 into the body; recast "So Nishmas comes from Peter," "a lot of things point to the story being true," and "there has to be

some part of this legend [that has] to be true."

14. Reconcile the two yahrzeits (ninth of Teves vs. Yom Kippur); correct "We commemorate it by fasting" to a conditional ("on this view the day would be…; the fast is not observed for that reason").

15. Neutral register for the Peter material: explain the פטר חמור pun; drop "cult"; shorten the Rome aside to one sentence; cut the Chabad joke, the eBay aside, and "do teshuvah." Decide the "Yeshke" convention.

16. Cut or explain the "like Shimon Kipa, by the Misnagdim" quip in XI.

17. Replace "the Maggid told him …" quotation with a short paraphrase; keep Yesod VeShoresh HaAvodah's simchah line; give gate and chapter if located.

18. Verify Nusach Ashkenaz vs. Sefard: והמפענח נעלמים (Sefard has it, Ashkenaz does not); state it in the body and tie it to Kloynimus.

19. Resolve the Mishnah Berurah "say Nishmas after davening" claim, or print "as the Rav understands the Mishnah Berurah"; reword II accordingly.

20. Test the three reasons for Shabbos against Yom Tov and daily recitation (two lines each); fix Reason Three to what the Tur actually says (note 24) or hedge ("the Rav was not sure it is the Tur").

21. Verify the status of Reb Moshe Wolfson before keeping זכר צדיק לברכה / ז"צל; remove "Reb Yisroel Dovid … 'the Munies'" and the Harborview aside.

22. Locate and cite: Chida (Simchas HaRegel), Algazi (work), Gaonic siddurim (page), Rokeach (simanim ×2), Machzor Vitry (the four unlocated), Sefer Chasidim, Baruch Ta'am, Tosafos on individuals-only, "Tashbetz." Anything not found: print "the Rav reports."

23. Rewrite all notes in third-person, source-first form: no "On Sefaria," "the editor," "I," or "the recording" in print notes; move unresolved items to a separate Editorial Log; remove nine editor's-parenthetical

interventions from the body (list in §4); remove the "16 August 2026 shiur" pointer in note 18; move the closing "Editor's source note" to a note or delete it.

24. Replace the dedication paragraph with one sentence or a front-matter dedication; replace every congregant's name with "a member of the shul."

25. Cut the duplicate Kosel passage in VII; consolidate the duplicate Birchos HaShachar remarks; cut "I don't know / confused" to two occurrences; cut the duplicated letter-by-letter derivation of שמעון in the Ninth of Teves paragraph.

26. Vocalise the acrostic initials inside the bold tag and add the רבקה line; unify Hebrew pointing and transliteration (list in §5); "Shirat" → "Shiras"; "Rabbi Ephrati" vs. "Efratti."

27. Convert "the Rav says / adds / notes" to direct narration in the narrative sections (V, XI) and cut the abstract to a three-sentence version; delete the twenty-nine "(the Rav: …)" parentheticals of recall and quotation.

28. Make the headings parallel in X; rename "Some Asides from the Room" and "Machzor Vitry's Fury, and Sefer Chasidim"; fix "VI. A Much Later Section (the Rav's Claim)."

29. Add "Rosh Chodesh Cheshvan" to the Mar-Cheshvan aside; replace "daf Kuf Yud Ches amud alef" and "daf Nun Tes" with "118a" and "59b."

## 6. Bottom Line

> *The reconciled text is fuller and the stories are better, but as a manuscript it is further from print than the earlier version was in one respect: more of the working process (dedications, names, editor's parentheticals, "see note") is now in the body. State the thesis (layers,*

> *accepted whole, with competing author-legends), fix the three chronology and extent errors (Kloynimus dates, the end of Nishmas, Algazi), put the Rishonim's rejection of the Peter legend ahead of the legend and say plainly that it is a legend, resolve the two yahrzeits, strip the residue and congregants' names, and turn the twelve unresolved footnotes into real citations or honest "the Rav reports" endnotes, and this is ready for the Sefer Edition.*

Produced by an independent-review pass — an agent given only the finished HTML and no prior exposure to the writing process. Intended as an outside second opinion for editorial refinement.